

Summary: Rapid growth causes success disasters

Narrative Summary

The speaker dedicates a significant portion of their time, roughly 70%, to what they term “success disasters.” These are situations where a company’s rapid growth has been so pronounced and successful that other critical systems and processes begin to break down under the strain. This phenomenon is particularly familiar to anyone who has worked in fast-growing organizations, citing examples like early Facebook, Uber, or DoorDash, where scaling challenges are felt viscerally.

Rapid expansion introduces a host of complex challenges across various business functions, including user acquisition, activation, and monetization. Companies experiencing such success disasters find themselves in a constant state of “firefighting,” frantically addressing one urgent issue after another. This perpetual scramble to keep up with growth can be an extremely painful and demanding experience for teams and individuals.

Ironically, while the internal experience is often one of struggle and urgency, external metrics typically paint a picture of resounding success, with charts showing consistent “green” and “up to the right” trends. This dichotomy can make the emotional toll of managing rapid growth particularly tough, despite the clear indicators of achievement. The speaker concludes by emphasizing the importance of stepping back to appreciate that, despite the difficulties, these are ultimately fortunate problems to have.

Key Points

- 70% of the speaker's time is dedicated to "success disasters."
- A "success disaster" occurs when rapid growth leads to the breakdown of other systems or processes.
- Companies like early Facebook, Uber, and DoorDash are prime examples of those experiencing these scaling challenges.
- Rapid growth creates significant challenges across key business areas such as acquisition, activation, and monetization.
- This leads to constant "firefighting" and a focus on urgent issues, which can be emotionally painful despite outward success.
- It's important to recognize that having problems stemming from rapid growth is ultimately a fortunate position.

Notable Quotes

- "Roughly 70% of what I spend my time on is what we internally refer to as success disasters." (0:00)
- "And that is where things have gone so well that other things are breaking." (0:04)
- "scaling this much just brings a lot of challenges each of those categories on acquisition, on activation, on monetization." (0:17)
- "There's just a ton of firefighting jumping from one urgent thing to another and it's often extremely painful." (0:26)
- "It can be quite tough emotionally still. And so you need to sort of step back and just realize like we're very lucky to have those problems." (0:34)